The Ivory Cradle SCHOOL

Milk Handling on Shift

Quick reference for home care with healthy, full-term infants

Expressed breast milk

Use the clock that matches how the milk was handled. [1, 2]

Freshly expressed breast milk

MEMORY CUE **4 hours, 4 days, 6 months best**

WHERE	TEMPERATURE	TIME
Room temperature	77°F (25°C) or cooler	Up to **4 hours**
Refrigerator	40°F (4°C) or colder	Up to **4 days**
Freezer	0°F (−18°C) or colder	**6 months for best quality**. CDC considers up to **12 months** acceptable. [1, 2]

Some people use **4-4-4** as a more conservative shortcut. Its 4 month freezer target is not a CDC or AAP limit.

THAWED, WARMED AND LEFTOVER MILK

Thawed in the refrigerator	**24 hours**	Use within **24 hours after it is fully thawed**. **Do not refreeze** fully thawed milk.
Warmed or brought to room temperature	**2 hours**	Use within **2 hours of warming or bringing to room temperature**.
Left after a feed	**2 hours**	Use within **2 hours after the baby finishes**, while honoring any earlier applicable limit.

Prepared infant formula

[3]

ONCE PREPARED

Use within **2 hours of preparation** at room temperature and **1 hour from the start of feeding**.

NOT USED RIGHT AWAY

If it will not be used right away, **refrigerate promptly** before feeding and use within **24 hours**.

AFTER THE FEED

Discard formula left in the bottle when the feed ends.

Practical habits that help on shift

Label first.

Put the **expression date** on the container. Add the time when it matters for the shift, and put **older milk where it will be used first**. Freeze in small portions and leave room for expansion. [1, 4]

Cool before combining.

Chill freshly expressed milk before adding it to already chilled milk. Use the **older milk's storage date** to work out the limit. [2]

Warm only if needed.

Milk can be served cold. To warm it, place the **sealed container in warm water**. **Skip the microwave.** Gently swirl to mix separated fat. [1]

Check the history.

If the milk type, timing, or storage is unclear, **set it aside and check with the parent**. Follow any clinician-directed feeding or storage instructions.

SOURCES [1] CDC Breast Milk Storage · [2] CDC Storage FAQ · [3] CDC Formula Preparation · [4] AAP Breast Milk Storage